Country Profile: German Democratic Republic

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 1
- Plurality religion: Atheism
- Official language: None
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Germans

Historical Background

After World War II, in 1949, the German Democratic Republic (GDR) was established in the Soviet-occupied zone of Germany as a socialist state. It was governed by the Socialist Unity Party (SED) and heavily influenced by Soviet policies. The regime's stability began to wane in the late 1980s, culminating in large-scale protests and the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989. In 1990, free elections took place. Negotiations between East and West Germany followed, leading to the formal reunification of both states and the dissolution of the GDR.

Between 1949 and 1990, the GDR did not experience significant border changes, as its territorial boundaries remained the same from its creation to its dissolution.[1]

Groups

- **Germans** constituted the core ethnic group in the GDR, forming an absolute majority of its population.[2] They primarily spoke Standard German, the country's de facto national language. The religious landscape changed significantly over the state's existence: around 81% of the population identified as Protestant at the GDR's founding in 1949, but by 1989, approximately 70% considered themselves non-religious, largely due to the Communist regime's aggressive anti-religious

[1] Jarausch, 1997.
[2] Franzmann, 2009.

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policies.[3] The remaining share of Germans largely continued to adhere to the Protestant faith, with a small proportion of Roman Catholics. Germans are not a racial group *per se* in the NBP dataset's understanding. However, racial ideology and racialization of all groups in Germany under the Nazi regime (1933–1945) shaped perceptions of German identity during this past phase in German history.[4]

State Profile

Official Language

The GDR's constitutional provisions did not specify an official state language. Nonetheless, Standard German functioned as the de facto national language, as evidenced by the constitution's use of German and its widespread employment in government, education, and public life.

Official Religion

The 1949 Constitution of the GDR established the separation of church and state, as stated in Article 43: "There shall be no state [established] church."[5] The subsequent constitutions upheld this principle.[6]

Education Policies

The structure of the education system in the GDR stood in stark contrast to that of West Germany. A defining characteristic of the GDR's educational framework was its strict centralization and standardization, with the state maintaining exclusive control over all aspects of schooling. This monopoly on education effectively prohibited **private schools** from operating.[7] Initially, the GDR established an eight-year comprehensive school (*Einheitsschule*) and a four-year upper secondary school during the Soviet Occupation Zone era. These were later replaced by a unified 10-year general education polytechnical high school (*Polytechnische Oberschule*).[8]

[3] Pollack, 1994; Gert, 2020; Sterr, 2000.
[4] Weindling, 2022.
[5] Constitution of the German Democratic Republic, 1949.
[6] See Art. 39 of the Constitution of the German Democratic Republic, 1968.
[7] Law on the Unified Socialist Education System of 25 February 1965
[8] Dobert, H. 2015.

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Language Education Policies

The language of instruction throughout the GDR's education system was consistently Standard German. While some specialized classes placed increased emphasis on foreign languages, most notably Russian, these languages were always taught as separate subjects.[9]

Religious Education Policies

The 1949 GDR Constitution's Articles 40 and 44 nominally guaranteed the right of religious communities to provide religious education in schools, with teaching staff chosen by the church and participation determined by the parents.[10] Despite these formal provisions, state policies in practice actively promoted secularization, erecting various barriers that hampered religious instruction for children. As a result, while the constitutional framework appeared to protect religious education rights, the actual implementation significantly curtailed the presence of religious teaching in public schools.

Bans and Restrictions

Restrictions of religious publications and proselytizing (Protestantism, Roman Catholicism)

Between 1949 and 1990, the GDR imposed significant restrictions on religious publications and proselytizing, despite formally guaranteeing freedom of religion in its constitution. While individuals were allowed to privately practice their faith and access religious materials such as Bibles in bookstores, the unsolicited distribution of religious documents was strictly prohibited. Furthermore, all religious publications were subject to rigorous state censorship, limiting their content and availability. Proselytizing, as distinct from private religious exercise, was not protected under the constitutional provisions. This effectively curtailed the public propagation of faith.[11]

Demographic Engineering and Violence

Forced Relocations

During the GDR era, two major waves of forced relocations occurred: "Aktion Grenze" or "Aktion Ungeziefer" in 1952 and "Aktion Festigung" or "Aktion Kornblume" in 1961,

[9] Huschner, A. 1997.
[10] Constitution of the German Democratic Republic, 1949.
[11] Stackhouse, 1981.

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affecting approximately 12,000 individuals. These actions targeted "politically unreliable" people near the border with West Germany, relocating them to central parts of the state to enhance governmental control.[12] These relocations were not directed at any specific ethnic, racial, religious, or national group; they demonstrate a strategy of political suppression rather than ethnic targeting.

Constitutions and Laws

The first constitution of the GDR was adopted in 1949. Both the preamble and Article 1 referenced the German people as a unified entity, stating, "[t]he [German Democratic] Republic decides on all issues which are essential to the existence and development of the German people as a whole."[13] Article 41 (1) enshrined universal religious freedom, declaring, that "[e]very citizen shall enjoy full freedom of faith and conscience. The undisturbed practice of religion shall be protected by the Republic."[14]

The 1968 Constitution, rooted in Marxist-Leninist ideology, was a distinctly Communist document. However, it maintained the general reference to the German nation, referring to it in the preamble as "the whole German nation," and also preserved the principle of religious freedom. Article 39 (1) guaranteed that "[e]very citizen of the German Democratic Republic has the right to profess a religious faith and to perform religious acts."[15]

The 1974 amendments to the 1968 Constitution adjusted its language, replacing references to the "German nation" in the preamble with references to the "German working class."[16] The constitutional provisions guaranteeing religious freedom remained unchanged.

Citizenship Laws

Citizenship in the German Democratic Republic (GDR) was primarily determined by descent, birth within its territory, or through conferral. According to par. 1 of the relevant law, individuals were recognized as GDR citizens if they were German citizens at the time of the GDR's foundation, resided within its borders, and retained their citizenship.[17] Those

[12] Onnen, 2022; Poutrus, 2005.
[13] Constitution of the German Democratic Republic, 1949.
[14] Constitution of the German Democratic Republic, 1949.
[15] Constitution of the German Democratic Republic, 1968.
[16] Constitution of the German Democratic Republic, 1968. Amended in 1974.
[17] Gesetz über die Staatsangehörigkeit der Deutschen Demokratischen Republik, 1967.

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living outside the GDR at its foundation could also claim citizenship if they had not acquired another nationality and formally registered their intent to do so.

From 1967 to 1990, the citizenship laws of the GDR provided conditional birthright citizenship for children born to foreign parents in its territory. According to the Law on the Citizenship of the German Democratic Republic, par. 6 (1), a child born in the GDR automatically acquired GDR citizenship if they did not inherit another citizenship at birth.[18] This marked a departure from the earlier *Reichs- und Staatsangehörigkeitsgesetz* (RuStAG) of 1913, which excluded birthright citizenship for non-Germans.[19]

National Anthem(s)

The national anthem of the German Democratic Republic, "Auferstanden aus Ruinen" ("Risen from Ruins"), was adopted on November 5, 1949. Written by Johannes R. Becher in German, the anthem reflects the GDR's political ideology, emphasizing collective solidarity and socialist ideals. Phrases such as "Let us plough, let us build" call for active participation in rebuilding the nation, underscoring a focus on labor and reconstruction as cornerstones of progress. The anthem also makes an ambiguous reference to a collective enemy with the line "If we unite as brothers, we beat the people's enemy." Additionally, its references to "Germany, our fatherland" and "Germany united fatherland" express a vision of national unity.[20]

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[18] Gesetz über die Staatsangehörigkeit der Deutschen Demokratischen Republik, 1967.
[19] Hailbronner and Farahat, 2020.
[20] Nationalanthems.info, 2024.

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